

KHANNA'S
BANDWALLAS
IN PRACTICE
(RIGHT)
AND THE
LAST BITE



ART EXHIBITION

The Story TELLER

He may forget where he kept his spectacles just a minute ago but ask him about his journey by sea from England to India as a 17-year-old returning from school and Krishen Khanna remembers every detail, from the name of his cabin mate to the amount, Rs 50, he had to borrow when he landed in Delhi. The journey, as well as his experience of climbing Java's Borobudur temple found its way into the 7 ft by 8 ft Chola mural he did which will be one of the works displayed at a comprehensive retrospective at Lalit Kala Akademi, Delhi, between January 23 and February 5. Organised by Saffronart, it captures the work of the 84-year-old artist who loves telling stories, whether it is about how his elder daughter once dealt with a too-smart boy at a bus stop or how he met the artist Mark Rothko quite by chance at a dinner in New York. It's the same flair for the narrative that imbues his work. It could be two boys eating watermelon or it could be migrant labourers at Gyaniji's dhaba. They reflect the man, who could have been a hot shot banker, but chose to give it up to pursue his love for art, sustained by his remarkable father's blessings and his wife's support. Before he got a studio at

Garhi, he worked out of the barsati of a small two bedroom flat in Jangpura, which housed his parents, his widowed sister, his younger brother, his wife and three children. It was here that he painted, often with good friend and fellow progressive M.F. Husain. Those were wonderful years of growing together, both personally and professionally. "(S.H.) Raza gave me a list of his buyers in London, I did the same for Tyeb (Mehta). We were all expanding the trade. There was no attrition," he recalls. The art market's sudden interest in his late friend Mehta, who succeeded him as a Rockefeller Fellow, strikes him as odd given that he, as chairman of the National Gallery of Modern Art purchasing committee, once had to forcefully buy a painting by the artist because he needed money for his daughter's wedding. Khanna can't quite say how many canvases he's painted. It could be 4,000, but then he's often surprised when he encounters his own work. He believes commercialism has moved the artist from the centre to the periphery, with impresarios becoming more important than the artist. And the bureaucracy more important than aesthetics. Six of his paintings, mentioned in the catalogue, and given to the Prince of Wales Museum in Mumbai by the Jehangir Nicholson Collection, cannot be shown because they did not write to the director in time. It's typical, but Khanna doesn't have the time to mope. He's too busy thinking of what to paint next. **by Kaveree Bamzai**